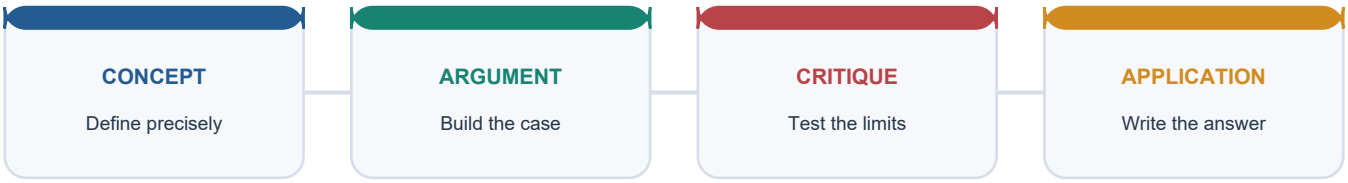
SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The British Conquest of Bengal (Plassey 1757, Buxar 1764, Dual Government) - Solved Practice Workbook

GS-I Modern Indian History | 32 solved MCQs, PYQs and Mains models

LEARNING PATH



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The British Conquest of Bengal (Plassey 1757, Buxar 1764, Dual Government) - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Why was the Jagat Seth banking house politically important in mid-eighteenth-century Bengal?

A. Its credit network linked court finance, revenue remittance and long-distance trade, giving it leverage in regime change B. It commanded the Nawab's field army and appointed the Mir Bakshi C. It held the Mughal Diwani of Bengal before the Company D. It operated only as a European agency house in Calcutta

Answer: A.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Correct: control of credit and treasury flows made the Jagat Seths indispensable to the court and influential in the Plassey conspiracy.
- **B.** Wrong: military command belonged to office-holders such as the Mir Bakshi, not the banking house.
- **C.** Wrong: the banking house financed the state but did not possess the imperial Diwani.
- **D.** Wrong: it was an Indian banking network centred on Murshidabad, not a European Calcutta agency house.

Trap: Do not reduce bankers to passive financiers; their control of credit could shape political coalitions without making them formal rulers.

Q2. Which condition most weakened Siraj-ud-Daulah's position immediately after his accession in 1756?

A. The Mughal emperor had already abolished the Bengal Nawabship B. Court factions and rival claimants combined with distrust of powerful commanders and financiers C. Bengal had no functioning revenue administration D. The Company already held the Diwani of Bengal

Answer: B.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: the Nawabship continued as a powerful Mughal successor-state institution.
- **B.** Correct: succession insecurity and divided elite loyalties narrowed Siraj's room for manoeuvre before open conflict.
- **C.** Wrong: Bengal possessed a wealthy and functioning revenue system; the crisis was political, not administrative vacuum.
- **D.** Wrong: the Company received the Diwani only in 1765.

Trap: Do not explain Siraj's fall solely through youth or temperament; the structure of court faction was decisive.

Q3. Why did Clive and Watson seize the French factory at Chandernagore in March 1757, before any confrontation with Siraj-ud-Daulah?

A. Because the 1717 farman entitled the Company to seize rival European factories during wartime B. On the direct written order of Mir Jafar C. To remove Siraj's potential French counterweight while the Plassey conspiracy was maturing D. Because Chandernagore had itself attacked Fort William in 1756

Answer: C.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** The 1717 farman was a Company-only trade privilege from the Nawab; it granted no wartime licence to seize other Europeans' factories.
- **B.** Mir Jafar's alliance with Clive was still forming in early-to-mid 1757 and he issued no such order; this option assigns agency to an actor not yet in command of events.

- **C.** Correct: this was a calculated pre-emptive move, tied to the wider Anglo-French war, to remove Siraj's potential French counterweight while the Plassey conspiracy was maturing.
- **D.** No such Chandernagore attack on Fort William occurred in 1756; the causal direction here is invented.

Trap: Do not assume a defensive-retaliation logic mirrors the earlier Calcutta crisis; no such French provocation exists in the record, so the real driver is pre-emption, not retaliation.

Q4. What is the principal source-critical problem with the Holwell account of the 'Black Hole of Calcutta'?

A. It was independently verified by three separate Company officials before publication B. It was written by an anonymous Bengali chronicler with no connection to the Company C. Modern forensic examination of the Fort William guardroom has settled the exact death toll D. It rests on a single interested narrator with no independently corroborated casualty count

Answer: D.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** No independent verification by other Company officials exists; the account's defining weakness is precisely the absence of such corroboration.
- **B.** Holwell was not anonymous and was not a neutral Bengali chronicler; he was a named, interested Company official, the opposite of this description.
- **C.** No forensic examination has settled a death toll; the episode remains explicitly disputed in scholarship, so claiming settlement overstates the evidence.
- **D.** Correct: Holwell was a Company official and self-described survivor with a direct personal and institutional stake in the story, and no independent account corroborates his specific casualty figures.

Trap: Do not assume 'well-known history' must mean 'forensically settled'; the correct exam position is explicit agnosticism about scale, not false certainty either way.

Q5. Why did Mir Qasim shift his capital from Murshidabad to Munger after 1760?

A. To gain distance from Calcutta's overbearing influence while positioning himself closer to his own recruits and revenue base B. The Jagat Seths refused to extend him further credit at Murshidabad C. Murshidabad had been destroyed in the Calcutta crisis fighting D. Munger was closer to the Mughal emperor's court at Delhi

Answer: A.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Correct: the move was a deliberate assertion of administrative and military independence from Company oversight, gaining distance from Calcutta while positioning nearer his own recruitment and revenue base.
- **B.** No credit refusal by the Jagat Seths is recorded as the trigger for the capital shift; this invents a banking-dispute cause not in evidence.
- **C.** Murshidabad was not destroyed in 1756-57 fighting, which centred on Calcutta and Fort William, not the Nawabi capital.
- **D.** Munger (in Bihar) is not meaningfully closer to Delhi than Murshidabad in a way that explains the move; this option misstates the geographic logic.

Trap: Do not reach for a Mughal-court explanation by reflex; the real driver is distance from Company-dominated Calcutta, not proximity to Delhi.

Q6. What was Mir Qasim's stated aim in abolishing internal transit duties in 1763?

A. To punish Indian merchants who had collaborated with the Company B. Equal, uniform taxation for Indian and European merchants alike C. To comply with a direct order from the Mughal emperor Shah Alam II D. To raise additional revenue for his own treasury by taxing all trade at a higher combined rate

Answer: B.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** The measure benefited, not punished, Indian merchants by removing their competitive disadvantage against duty-free Company traders.
- **B.** Correct: the explicit aim was competitive parity -- equal, uniform taxation for Indian and European traders alike, removing Company servants' dastak-based advantage.
- **C.** Shah Alam II issued no such order; the initiative was Mir Qasim's own administrative reform, not an imperial directive.
- **D.** The measure abolished duties rather than raising them, and its purpose was equalisation, not revenue maximisation -- this option reverses the actual fiscal direction.

Trap: Do not assume any fiscal reform must aim to raise revenue, when this measure explicitly cut duties to equalise competition, at real cost to Mir Qasim's own collections.

Q7. Which three parties formed the coalition defeated at the Battle of Buxar in 1764?

A. Mir Jafar, the Jagat Seths and Rai Durlabh B. Warren Hastings, Muhammad Reza Khan and Raja Shitab Rai C. Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II D. Siraj-ud-Daulah, Amichand and Mir Madan

Answer: C.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** This names the 1757 Plassey conspirators, a set from a different event seven years earlier, not the 1764 Buxar coalition.
- **B.** This mixes Dual Government-era administrators from after 1765 with a Governor-General figure; none of them fought at Buxar in 1764.
- **C.** Correct: Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula of Awadh and the fugitive Mughal emperor Shah Alam II formed the coalition defeated at Buxar.
- **D.** Siraj-ud-Daulah was already dead (deposed and killed in 1757) by the time of Buxar, and Amichand and Mir Madan belong to the Plassey conspiracy/battle, not this coalition.

Trap: Plassey's 1757 cast of characters is often wrongly transplanted onto the 1764 Buxar coalition, which is an entirely distinct set of actors.

Q8. What was the principal reason the Buxar coalition lost to a numerically smaller Company force?

A. Shah Alam II refused to commit any troops to the battle B. Heavy monsoon rains disabled the coalition's cavalry C. The coalition lacked artillery of any kind D. The coalition's segmented command -- three separate treasuries and commanders with no shared war-chest -- could not match the Company's single unified chain of command

Answer: D.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Shah Alam II did commit forces as part of the coalition; claiming total non-participation misstates his role.
- **B.** No monsoon-disruption explanation is supported; October is outside the main monsoon season in this region, and the sources do not cite weather as decisive.
- **C.** The coalition did field artillery; the defeat is explained by command fragmentation, not an absence of equipment.
- **D.** Correct: the coalition's structural weakness was three separate treasuries and commanders with no shared war-chest, unable to match the Company's single unified chain of command under Munro.

Trap: Do not default to an equipment-gap explanation; the actual decisive factor was command and financial structure, not weaponry.

Q9. What does Clive's use of a genuine white treaty and a false red treaty in dealing with Amichand reveal?

A. Company leaders used deliberate deception inside the conspiracy when a broker threatened disclosure B. The Plassey alliance was publicly ratified by Shah Alam II C. Amichand commanded the loyal Nawabi wing at Plassey D. The French guaranteed Mir Jafar's succession

Answer: A.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Correct: the two-treaty device was designed to deceive Amichand after he demanded payment for silence.
- **B.** Wrong: the Mughal emperor did not ratify the 1757 conspiracy.
- **C.** Wrong: Amichand was a broker, whereas Mir Madan and Mohan Lal led loyal resistance.
- **D.** Wrong: the French did not guarantee Mir Jafar's accession.

Trap: The red-treaty episode is evidence of Company deception within a wider Indian-European conspiracy, not a separate diplomatic treaty.

Q10. Which pair correctly identifies two loyal defenders of Siraj-ud-Daulah at Plassey?

A. Jagat Seth and Amichand B. Mir Madan and Mohan Lal C. Mir Jafar and Rai Durlabh D. Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II

Answer: B.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: Jagat Seth financed regime change and Amichand acted as a broker in the conspiracy.
- **B.** Correct: Mir Madan and Mohan Lal led the limited wing that continued genuine resistance for Siraj.
- **C.** Wrong: both figures were aligned with the conspiracy and withheld effective support.
- **D.** Wrong: they belonged to the later Buxar coalition, not the Plassey battlefield.

Trap: Do not label every Indian commander a conspirator; loyal resistance remained real even within a politically compromised army.

Q11. What did the Treaty of Alinagar in February 1757 chiefly accomplish?

A. It granted the Company the Diwani of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa B. It made Mir Jafar Nawab before Plassey C. It restored Company privileges and compensation after the Calcutta crisis without resolving the deeper political conflict D. It annexed Chandernagore to the Nawab's dominions

Answer: C.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: the Diwani grant followed Buxar in 1765.
- **B.** Wrong: Mir Jafar was installed only after Plassey in June 1757.
- **C.** Correct: Alinagar restored the pre-crisis commercial position, but distrust and conspiracy continued.
- **D.** Wrong: Chandernagore was seized by Clive and Watson in March 1757.

Trap: Do not treat Alinagar as a durable peace settlement; it was an interim restoration during a rapidly escalating conflict.

Q12. Why was the grant of the 24 Parganas after Plassey significant?

A. It made Clive Mughal emperor B. It transferred all Bengal revenue to the Company in 1757 C. It restored the French factory at Chandernagore D. It gave the Company a territorial-revenue base near Calcutta while Mir Jafar remained the nominal Nawab

Answer: D.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: Clive received influence and a jagir, not imperial sovereignty.
- **B.** Wrong: comprehensive revenue authority came only with the 1765 Diwani.
- **C.** Wrong: the grant concerned land and revenue around Calcutta, not French restoration.
- **D.** Correct: the grant strengthened the Company's local fiscal and territorial position before the later Diwani.

Trap: The 24 Parganas were an important intermediate gain, but not the same legal title as the later Diwani.

Q13. What was Amichand (Omichand)'s specific role in the events preceding Plassey?

A. A wealthy merchant-broker who demanded a commission for his conspiracy role and was deceived by Clive's forged 'red treaty' B. The Mughal-appointed governor of Bihar C. Bengal's Diwan and chief revenue officer D. Commander of Siraj-ud-Daulah's cavalry wing

Answer: A.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Correct: Amichand was a wealthy merchant-broker central to financing and negotiating the conspiracy, who demanded a commission and was deceived by Clive's forged 'red treaty'.
- **B.** Bihar's governorship is not Amichand's role; he operated as a Murshidabad-based merchant-broker, not a provincial administrator.
- **C.** Bengal's Diwan role in this period belonged to Rai Durlabh, not Amichand, so this option confuses two distinct conspiracy figures.
- **D.** Amichand held no military command; Siraj-ud-Daulah's loyal military wing was led by Mir Madan and Mohan Lal, not by Amichand.

Trap: Amichand and Rai Durlabh are both civilian (non-military) conspirators, and students often swap their specific institutional roles.

Q14. Robert Clive's role at Plassey is best described in modern analysis as combining which two functions?

A. Company director in London and Parliamentary representative B. Military commander and chief political negotiator of the conspiracy C. Mughal-appointed provincial governor and religious mediator D. Naval admiral and chief revenue collector

Answer: B.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Clive held no London directorship or Parliamentary seat at the time of Plassey; this option displaces his role into an unrelated institutional setting.
- **B.** Correct: Clive personally led both the nominal battlefield operation and the secret political negotiations with Mir Jafar's camp, central to reading Plassey as a political coup.
- **C.** Clive was never a Mughal-appointed provincial governor or a religious mediator; these titles belong to no figure in this topic's actual cast.
- **D.** Clive was not a naval officer (that role belonged to Admiral Watson) nor was he a revenue collector before the post-1765 Diwani administration existed.

Trap: Do not conflate Clive with Watson's naval role at the earlier Calcutta recapture; keep the army-command-plus-political-negotiation description specific to Clive.

Q15. Which statement is the most defensible treatment of mortality estimates for the Bengal famine of 1770?

A. A precise death total can be treated as census-confirmed because it is often repeated B. Mortality cannot be discussed at all because no environmental shock occurred C. The scale was severe, but exact totals should be attributed as disputed estimates rather than settled counts D. Revenue policy alone supplies a complete numerical measure of mortality

Answer: C.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: repetition in later accounts is not equivalent to a contemporary census.
- **B.** Wrong: harvest failure, drought and disease formed the environmental trigger.
- **C.** Correct: the catastrophe's severity is clear, while exact mortality totals remain estimates that require attribution.
- **D.** Wrong: fiscal rigidity amplified vulnerability but cannot itself produce an exact death count.

Trap: Distinguish confidence about severe impact from false precision about a single mortality figure.

Q16. Which of the following was NOT part of the immediate 1757 Plassey settlement?

A. Company compensation payments and territorial concessions B. Mir Jafar's installation as Nawab of Bengal C. Confirmation of the Company's Calcutta trading privileges D. The grant of Diwani rights over Bengal, Bihar and Orissa

Answer: D.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Compensation payments and territorial concessions (including the 24-Parganas zamindari) were genuinely part of the immediate 1757 settlement.
- **B.** Mir Jafar's installation as the Company's client Nawab is the defining outcome of the 1757 settlement.
- **C.** Confirmation of the Company's Calcutta trading privileges was also part of the immediate post-Plassey settlement.
- **D.** Correct as the exception: the Diwani grant came only in 1765 via the Treaty of Allahabad, eight years after Plassey, so it was not part of the 1757 settlement.

Trap: This question's trap is structural (a NOT-question): students who recall the Diwani as generally linked to 'the conquest of Bengal' may wrongly place it at 1757 instead of 1765.

Q17. Which combination best represents Mir Qasim's attempt to restore Nawabi capacity from Munger?

A. Administrative centralisation, military reorganisation and an effort to remove unequal trade advantages B. Dependence on Calcutta, abolition of the army and surrender of customs C. Alliance with Mir Jafar and restoration of the 1757 settlement D. Immediate annexation of Awadh and Delhi

Answer: A.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Correct: Munger, reorganised forces and fiscal parity formed one coherent recovery project.
- **B.** Wrong: Mir Qasim moved away from Calcutta's influence and strengthened rather than abolished his army.
- **C.** Wrong: Mir Qasim replaced Mir Jafar and tried to escape the client arrangement.
- **D.** Wrong: he neither annexed Awadh nor controlled Delhi.

Trap: Treat the capital shift, army reform and commercial policy as connected state-building measures, not isolated anecdotes.

Q18. After his 1763 defeats, where did Mir Qasim take refuge, setting up the coalition that fought at Buxar?

A. The Maratha court at Pune B. Shuja-ud-Daula's court in Awadh C. The Sikh Misls in Punjab D. The Mysore court under Haidar Ali

Answer: B.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** The Maratha court at Pune played no role in sheltering Mir Qasim or forming the Buxar coalition; this option displaces the refuge onto an unconnected regional power.
- **B.** Correct: Mir Qasim fled to Awadh, where Shuja-ud-Daula's protection and the fugitive emperor Shah Alam II's shared interest formed the coalition that met the Company at Buxar in 1764.
- **C.** The Sikh Misls in Punjab are geographically and politically unconnected to Mir Qasim's 1763 flight and the Buxar coalition's formation.
- **D.** Haidar Ali's Mysore had no involvement in this specific 1763-64 sequence, which belongs to Bengal-Awadh-Mughal politics, not the Deccan.

Trap: Do not import that regional actor into this Bengal-Awadh-centred sequence, crossing a topic boundary.

Q19. The Battle of Buxar was fought on which date, at a location on which river?

A. 2 January 1757, on the Hooghly at Calcutta B. 12 August 1765, on the Ganges near Allahabad C. 22 October 1764, on the Ganges near Buxar in present-day Bihar D. 23 June 1757, on the Bhagirathi-Hooghly

Answer: C.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** This date and river belong to the Company's recapture of Calcutta, a distinct 1757 event, not Buxar.
- **B.** This date belongs to the Treaty of Allahabad's signing, a diplomatic instrument, not the battle itself, and misapplies it to a battlefield location.
- **C.** Correct: Buxar was fought on 22 October 1764, on the Ganges near Buxar in present-day Bihar.
- **D.** This date and river belong to the Battle of Plassey, a separate 1757 engagement fought downstream in Bengal.

Trap: Plassey's well-known date (23 June 1757) is often misapplied to Buxar by students who blur the topic's two decisive battles into one.

Q20. Major Hector Munro commanded the Company forces at Buxar; which of these best describes his command's key structural advantage?

A. Overwhelming numerical superiority of at least five to one B. Superior knowledge of the local terrain from decades of prior residence C. Direct reinforcement from a simultaneous naval bombardment D. A single, unified chain of command, unlike the coalition's three separate treasuries and commanders

Answer: D.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Munro's force was in fact outnumbered by the coalition, not overwhelmingly superior in numbers; this option reverses the actual troop-strength balance.
- **B.** No such decades-long terrain familiarity is attributed to Munro in the sources; this option invents an unsupported personal-experience claim.
- **C.** Buxar was an inland battle on the Ganges with no naval bombardment role; this option misapplies a coastal/riverine-assault image to an inland engagement.
- **D.** Correct: Munro's decisive advantage was a single, unified chain of command, contrasting with the coalition's three separate treasuries and commanders.

Trap: Do not assume the smaller, victorious Company force must have had a numbers advantage, when the real advantage was structural (command unity), not numerical.

Q21. Which statement correctly distinguishes the two Allahabad treaties of 1765?

A. Shah Alam II's treaty of 12 August granted the Diwani; Shuja-ud-Daula's treaty of 16 August restored Awadh under indemnity and alliance terms B. The Shuja-ud-Daula treaty preceded Buxar C. The Shah Alam II treaty restored Awadh, while the Shuja treaty granted the Diwani D. Both were signed on 12 August and both granted the Diwani

Answer: A.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Correct: the Diwani grant and Awadh restoration were distinct instruments dated 12 and 16 August respectively.
- **B.** Wrong: both settlements followed the Company's victory at Buxar.
- **C.** Wrong: this reverses the parties and outcomes.
- **D.** Wrong: the instruments were four days apart and performed different legal functions.

Trap: The singular shorthand 'Treaty of Allahabad' must not erase either the separate dates or the separate legal jobs.

Q22. Who were appointed as the Company's principal Naib Diwans (deputy revenue administrators) for Bengal and Bihar respectively during the Dual Government?

A. Robert Clive for Bengal and Hector Munro for Bihar B. Muhammad Reza Khan for Bengal and Raja Shitab Rai for Bihar C. Mir Jafar for Bengal and Mir Qasim for Bihar D. Warren Hastings for Bengal and Robert Clive for Bihar

Answer: B.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Clive and Munro were Company military-political figures, not the Indian Naib Diwans who actually ran day-to-day revenue administration.
- **B.** Correct: Muhammad Reza Khan and Raja Shitab Rai were the actual Indian intermediaries administering revenue for the Company in Bengal and Bihar respectively.
- **C.** Mir Jafar and Mir Qasim were earlier Nawabs (1757-63), not the post-1765 Naib Diwan appointees of the Dual Government period.
- **D.** Hastings and Clive were senior Company officials of different periods, not the Indian deputy revenue administrators this question asks about.

Trap: students who recall Mir Jafar and Mir Qasim as Bengal's leading names from this topic may wrongly extend their roles into the later, distinct Naib Diwan appointments.

Q23. In 1772, Warren Hastings ended the Dual Government by taking which specific step?

A. Transferring the Diwani back to the Mughal emperor B. Restoring full sovereign power to the Nawab of Bengal C. Having the Company itself 'stand forth as Diwan,' assuming direct revenue administration rather than governing through Naib Diwans D. Formally annexing Bengal to the British Crown

Answer: C.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** No such reverse transfer occurred; the Diwani stayed with the Company, which instead changed how it administered that title.
- **B.** No restoration of full sovereign power to the Nawab occurred; the Nawab's already-nominal position was not strengthened in 1772.
- **C.** Correct: Hastings's own phrase, that the Company would 'stand forth as Diwan,' captures the shift to direct administration, replacing indirect rule through Naib Diwans.
- **D.** Crown annexation came only in 1858, eighty-six years later, following the 1857 revolt, not in 1772.

Trap: Do not collapse Company administrative reforms into the much later 1858 Crown annexation, a serious and frequent chronological overclaim.

Q24. Why did the Dual Government weaken corrective administration even when revenue collection continued?

A. The Company lacked any interest in Bengal revenue B. The Nawab held both effective power and adequate funds C. All offices were abolished and no Indian deputies remained D. The Company controlled the resource base while visible administrative responsibility remained with a financially weakened Nawabi establishment

Answer: D.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: revenue was the Company's central interest after the Diwani.
- **B.** Wrong: the Nawab retained nominal responsibility without the resources needed to exercise it effectively.
- **C.** Wrong: Muhammad Reza Khan and Raja Shitab Rai remained indispensable deputies.
- **D.** Correct: power and responsibility were separated, weakening accountability and response capacity.

Trap: Explain the constitutional mismatch itself; do not reduce failure to the personal character of one official.

Q25. In a comparative assessment, why is Buxar often judged strategically more decisive than Plassey, despite Plassey's greater fame?

A. Buxar, through the subsequent Treaty of Allahabad, produced the Company's formal legal revenue title (the Diwani), whereas Plassey only changed Bengal's ruling personnel B. Plassey is historiographically disputed while Buxar's outcome faces no historical debate C. Buxar involved a larger territorial area than all of Bengal D. Buxar was fought entirely without any Indian participants on either side

Answer: A.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Correct: the decisive distinction is legal-institutional -- Buxar led, via the Treaty of Allahabad, to the Company's formal Diwani, while Plassey only changed who sat on Bengal's throne.
- **B.** Both battles in fact involve historiographical debate (over causation, agency and significance); this option wrongly claims one is uncontested and the other is not.
- **C.** Territorial scale is not the basis of the comparison; both events occurred within the same broader Bengal-Bihar-Awadh theatre, and area size is not the analytical criterion used here.
- **D.** Both battles were fought predominantly with Indian troops on most sides (including within the Company's own forces); claiming an absence of Indian participants at Buxar misstates composition.

Trap: Do not reach for a 'more/less disputed' framing; the real, examinable distinction is institutional (legal revenue title vs. mere regime change), not the degree of historiographical controversy.

Q26. Which historiographical interpretation best explains why the Jagat Seths, Mir Jafar and Rai Durlabh matter to the conquest of Bengal?

A. The environmental interpretation, because all three primarily responded to drought B. The collaboration interpretation, because local elites pursued institutional interests that enabled Company intervention C. The technological interpretation, because all three commanded superior artillery D. The isolationist interpretation, because Bengal's credit and court networks were irrelevant

Answer: B.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: famine causation does not explain the 1757 coalition of bankers and court figures.
- **B.** Correct: the collaboration lens highlights how Indian institutional choices helped make Company success possible.
- **C.** Wrong: these actors mattered through finance, office and political alignment, not superior weaponry.
- **D.** Wrong: Bengal's own credit and court networks were central to how conquest unfolded.

Trap: Using collaboration analytically does not erase coercion or imply equal gains between Indian allies and the Company.

Q27. What did Clive's personal jagir after Plassey illustrate about the early Company regime?

A. Clive became the hereditary Nawab of Bengal B. The Company had already ended all private trade by its servants C. Private enrichment and corporate political leverage could overlap within the client-Nawab settlement D. The jagir was a salary paid by the British Parliament

Answer: C.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: Mir Jafar remained Nawab; Clive did not inherit that office.
- **B.** Wrong: private trade and private enrichment remained major features of the period.
- **C.** Correct: personal fortunes, Company demands and Nawabi concessions were intertwined after regime change.
- **D.** Wrong: the jagir arose from the Bengal settlement, not a parliamentary salary.

Trap: Use the jagir to show the blurred boundary between servant enrichment and Company power, not to invent formal kingship.

Q28. A student calls Mir Jafar's post-Plassey payments a single bribe that ended once he became Nawab. What is the better interpretation?

A. Mir Jafar refused every Company demand after his accession B. All payments were voluntary charitable gifts unrelated to politics C. The payments transferred the Diwani immediately in 1757 D. Payments and concessions formed a continuing extraction cycle that deepened dependence and eventually exhausted the client regime

Answer: D.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: Mir Jafar's inability to meet escalating demands, not complete refusal, led to his deposition.
- **B.** Wrong: the transfers were embedded in regime change and coercive leverage.
- **C.** Wrong: the Diwani was granted by Shah Alam II in 1765.
- **D.** Correct: compensation, gifts, territorial concessions and renewed demands reinforced one another until Mir Jafar was replaced.

Trap: A one-time-bribe narrative misses the repeated client-extraction mechanism operating from 1757 to 1760.

Q29. A student writes: 'Mir Jafar and Jagat Seth led the coalition defeated at Buxar in 1764.' What is the correct remedial statement?

A. Mir Jafar and Jagat Seth were 1757 Plassey conspirators; the 1764 Buxar coalition instead comprised Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II B. Only Jagat Seth was present at Buxar; Mir Jafar was not involved in this period at all C. The statement is accurate as written D. Mir Jafar and Jagat Seth were present at Buxar but played a minor role

Answer: A.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Correct: Mir Jafar and Jagat Seth were 1757 Plassey conspirators, seven years and an entirely different set of actors removed from the 1764 Buxar coalition of Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II.
- **B.** Jagat Seth was not present at Buxar either; this option incorrectly retains one name from the false premise.
- **C.** The statement wrongly transplants Plassey's 1757 conspirators onto the entirely separate 1764 Buxar coalition, so it is not accurate.
- **D.** Neither figure was present at Buxar in any role, minor or otherwise; this option retains a false premise while only softening it.

Trap: Partial-correction options that retain a false premise (here, presence at Buxar) while only downgrading its importance are a recurring remedial-question distractor pattern in this topic.

Q30. What did the use of Muhammad Reza Khan in Bengal and Raja Shitab Rai in Bihar reveal about early Company rule?

A. The Company immediately replaced every Indian official with Europeans B. The Company depended on experienced Indian deputies to operate revenue administration while retaining decisive supervision C. The deputies exercised authority wholly independent of Company influence D. They commanded the Buxar coalition before entering administration

Answer: B.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** Wrong: institutional continuity and Indian expertise remained essential.
- **B.** Correct: indirect administration allowed the Company to extract revenue before it possessed a large European bureaucracy.
- **C.** Wrong: the deputies operated inside a Company-dominated structure.
- **D.** Wrong: neither deputy was a commander in the Buxar coalition.

Trap: Dependence on Indian intermediaries demonstrates administrative continuity, not equality of political power.

Q31. A student writes: 'The Dual Government of 1765-72 meant Bengal was ruled jointly and equally by two separate Nawabs.' What is the correct remedial statement?

A. It refers to joint rule by the Mughal emperor and the Nawab, with no Company role at all B. The statement is accurate as written C. The Dual Government was not a two-Nawab arrangement at all; it was the Company, holding the substantive Diwani, governing alongside a single Nawab's nominal Nizamat, with real power concentrated in the Company's Naib Diwans D. It refers to two separate Company Governors ruling different halves of Bengal

Answer: C.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** This option removes the Company entirely from the arrangement, when the Company's Diwani was in fact the substantive power-holder throughout.
- **B.** The statement misreads 'dual' as meaning two equal Nawabs, an equal-power reading the Dual Government's own paradox specifically contradicts.
- **C.** Correct: 'Dual' refers to the Diwani-Nizamat split between the Company and one Nawab's office, not to two rival Nawabs, with real power concentrated in the Company's Naib Diwans.
- **D.** No such two-Governor territorial division of Bengal existed; this option invents an administrative structure not present in the historical record.

Trap: 'dual' is an intuitive-sounding word that invites the equal-two-Nawabs misreading this question is specifically designed to correct.

Q32. A student writes: 'In 1772, Warren Hastings formally annexed Bengal to the British Crown, ending Mughal sovereignty.' What is the correct remedial statement?

A. The statement is accurate as written B. Hastings's 1772 action concerned only Awadh, not Bengal C. Hastings restored full Mughal sovereignty over Bengal in 1772, reversing the Company's role entirely D. In 1772, Hastings ended the Dual Government by having the Company itself 'stand forth as Diwan' and administer revenue directly -- an internal administrative shift, not a Crown annexation, which occurred only in 1858

Answer: D.

Explanation (option-by-option):

- **A.** The statement confuses an internal Company administrative reform with a Crown annexation that occurred eighty-six years later; it is not accurate.
- **B.** Hastings's 1772 action concerned Bengal's Dual Government directly, not a separate Awadh-only matter; this option misplaces the geography of the reform.
- **C.** No restoration of full Mughal sovereignty occurred in 1772; the reform deepened, rather than reversed, the Company's direct administrative control.

- **D.** Correct: in 1772, Hastings ended the Dual Government by having the Company itself 'stand forth as Diwan,' an internal administrative shift, not a Crown annexation, which came only in 1858 after the 1857 revolt.

Trap: This is the single most serious chronological overclaim in this topic, conflating 1772's internal administrative reform with 1858's formal Crown annexation, eighty-six years apart.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ Application 1 - Company armies and the Buxar lesson

Demand: Use the 2022 GS-I question on Company armies defeating larger Indian forces to build a Bengal-specific application.

Workbook model: Buxar shows that numerical strength did not automatically create military effectiveness. Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II brought a broad coalition, but each component retained separate political aims, treasuries and command structures. Hector Munro's force possessed a more unified chain of command, regular finance and disciplined battlefield coordination. The lesson is therefore institutional rather than racial or technological: the Company converted revenue, credit and central command into sustained military capacity. The Bengal case should be used as one illustration within the wider all-India answer, not as a complete explanation for every later Company victory.

PYQ Application 2 - Why famine incidence increased

Demand: Use the 2022 GS-I famine question without claiming that Company taxation caused drought.

Workbook model: The Bengal famine of 1770 illustrates how an environmental shock became a governance disaster. Poor harvests, drought and disease created scarcity, but rigid revenue demands, commercial priorities and the confused authority of the Dual Government weakened adaptation and relief. The Company possessed effective revenue power while the Nawab's establishment retained nominal public responsibility without adequate resources. Bengal therefore supports a layered explanation: climatic stress triggered the crisis, while extractive and unaccountable institutions magnified exposure, reduced corrective capacity and deepened mortality. Wider colonial famine policy must be added separately for an all-India answer.

Evidence Lab 1 - Build a five-date chronology

Write one institutional consequence beside each date: 20 June 1756, 23 June 1757, 22 October 1764, 12 August 1765 and 16 August 1765. The answer is complete only when the two Allahabad dates perform different legal jobs.

Evidence Lab 2 - Convert betrayal into analysis

Replace the sentence "Mir Jafar betrayed Siraj" with a three-part explanation using office, ambition and Company-backed regime change. Then add Jagat Seth finance as a separate causal strand.

Evidence Lab 3 - Compare the two decisive battles

Prepare a two-column comparison of Plassey and Buxar under four heads: military character, Indian actors, immediate result and long-term institutional effect. Do not assign the Diwani to Plassey.

Evidence Lab 4 - Explain the Dual Government in one diagram

Draw two arrows: Company -> revenue power and Nawab -> nominal public responsibility. Under the arrows, write the resulting paradox and connect it to weak corrective administration.

Evidence Lab 5 - Qualify a famine claim

Rewrite "Company policy caused the Bengal famine" into a defensible sentence that distinguishes environmental trigger, institutional amplifier and uncertainty over exact mortality.

Evidence Lab 6 - Use historiography without name-dropping

Write four one-line interpretations of Bengal's conquest: nationalist extraction, collaboration, corporate-state formation and Bengal political economy. Attach one piece of evidence to each.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE - WORKBOOK MODELS

Original Mains 1 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Explain how commercial privilege became a sovereignty conflict in Bengal before Plassey.

Model answer: The conflict began because a bounded commercial concession was stretched into political immunity. Farrukhsiyar's 1717 farman protected the Company's registered trade, but Company servants increasingly used dastaks for private transactions. This reduced Nawabi customs revenue and disadvantaged Indian merchants who still paid duties. The dispute widened when the Company fortified Calcutta without permission and resisted the Nawab's jurisdiction over persons and property within its settlement. Siraj-ud-Daulah therefore confronted more than a foreign merchant: he confronted a corporation claiming fiscal and territorial exceptions inside Bengal. The fall of Fort William in June 1756 expressed this struggle over sovereignty. Plassey followed only after the Company combined commercial grievance, military recovery and court conspiracy. Thus trade privilege did not mechanically cause conquest, but its unauthorised extension created the institutional conflict from which political intervention grew.

Original Mains 2 - 10 marks | 150 words

Question: Distinguish the historical significance of Plassey from that of Buxar.

Model answer: Plassey and Buxar were decisive in different ways. Plassey (23 June 1757) was primarily a political coup enabled by conspiracy. Mir Jafar, Rai Durlabh and the Jagat Seths helped neutralise Siraj-ud-Daulah's numerical strength, allowing the Company to install a dependent Nawab and extract payments and concessions. Buxar (22 October 1764), by contrast, was a genuine field victory over Mir Qasim, Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II. It demonstrated military predominance beyond Bengal's succession politics. Buxar also created the leverage for the two Allahabad treaties of August 1765, through which the Company received the Diwani and preserved Awadh as a buffer. Plassey opened Bengal's political system to Company control; Buxar made that control militarily credible and legally convertible into revenue sovereignty.

Original Mains 3 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Assess Mir Qasim's programme as an attempt to recover Nawabi capacity.

Model answer: Mir Qasim's programme was a state-recovery project rather than merely a personal quarrel with the Company. Installed in 1760, he shifted his capital to Munger to reduce dependence on Company-dominated Murshidabad, reorganised the army and tried to strengthen fiscal administration. The central conflict concerned inland trade. Company servants used duty exemptions to expand private commerce, while Indian merchants remained taxed. Mir Qasim's abolition of internal duties in 1763 sought equality by removing the Nawab's own duties for everyone. This restored competitive parity but sacrificed revenue, showing how sharply Company privilege constrained Nawabi choice. The Company opposed the measure because equality removed its servants' advantage. War followed, and Mir Qasim's defeat pushed him toward Shuja-ud-Daula and Shah Alam II before Buxar. His programme therefore revealed both the possibilities and limits of regional recovery: administrative relocation, military reform and fiscal equalisation could challenge Company privilege, but they could not overcome the corporation's combined military, financial and political resources.

Original Mains 4 - 15 marks | 250 words

Question: Analyse the strategic logic of the two Allahabad treaties of August 1765.

Model answer: The Allahabad settlement converted Buxar's military outcome into two complementary forms of power. On 12 August 1765, Shah Alam II granted the Company the Diwani of Bengal, Bihar and Orissa. The grant supplied legal revenue title in Mughal form, while the emperor received tribute and the districts of Kora and Allahabad. On 16 August, the separate treaty with Shuja-ud-Daula restored Awadh after indemnity and alliance obligations. The Company did not annex Awadh because a dependent buffer was strategically cheaper than direct rule and useful against powers farther west. The two instruments therefore performed different tasks: one institutionalised fiscal sovereignty in the east; the other organised strategic depth beyond Bengal. Their combined logic was selective expansion. The Company preferred recognised title, revenue access and indirect influence where these served its interests better than immediate annexation. Calling them simply the Treaty of Allahabad is acceptable shorthand only if their distinct parties, dates and functions remain clear.

Original Mains 5 - 20 marks | 250 words

Question: Examine how finance and Indian institutional actors shaped the Company's conquest of Bengal.

Model answer: Finance was not a background condition of Bengal's conquest; it was one of its principal mechanisms. The Jagat Seth banking house connected court politics, credit and large transfers, and supported regime change when Siraj-ud-Daulah appeared threatening to established interests. Mir Jafar offered the Company a client relationship through which compensation, concessions and the 24 Parganas grant could flow. Rai Durlabh's office and battlefield inactivity helped convert conspiracy into military outcome, while Amichand acted as a broker within the negotiations. After Plassey, repeated demands weakened Mir Jafar and encouraged his replacement by Mir Qasim. Yet Indian institutional agency also resisted Company power. Mir Madan and Mohan Lal fought at Plassey, and Mir Qasim attempted fiscal and military recovery from Munger. After the Diwani, Indian deputies remained indispensable to revenue administration because the Company lacked sufficient local capacity. The collaboration interpretation is therefore useful, but it requires qualification. Indian actors pursued their own interests; they did not collectively design colonial rule. As Company control over force, credit and revenue expanded, the relationship became increasingly unequal. Conquest was institutionally co-produced, but its durable gains accrued overwhelmingly to the Company.

Original Mains 6 - 20 marks | 250 words

Question: Discuss the relationship between the Dual Government and Bengal's vulnerability during the famine of 1770.

Model answer: The Dual Government did not create drought, but it made Bengal less capable of absorbing and governing scarcity. From 1765 the Company possessed the substantive Diwani and drew revenue through Indian deputies, while the Nawab's establishment retained nominal responsibility for policing, justice and public order without commensurate resources. This divided authority encouraged revenue extraction while obscuring who was accountable for corrective action. When poor harvests, drought and disease intensified scarcity in 1769-70, the institutional system lacked a clear and adequately funded relief authority. Revenue rigidity and commercial priorities could therefore amplify distress even though the environmental trigger remained real. The famine must not be reduced to one cause, and exact mortality figures should be presented as disputed estimates rather than census facts. Its historical significance lies in what it exposed: Company power had grown faster than its willingness to accept public responsibility. Warren Hastings's 1772 termination of the Dual Government did not erase colonial extraction, but it acknowledged that the fiction of Nawabi responsibility could no longer conceal the Company's effective authority.